

Free for all

The powers that be have announced that anyone using illegal software can be prosecuted for piracy and be sentenced to five years in prison.

Scared?

We need not be, for there is no such law. At least not yet!

Over the past decade we've been trying hard to computerise our businesses, increase PC penetration into our homes and generally create greater awareness about the benefits of IT. But the biggest stumbling block has always been the cost of technology.

Add the cost of legal software to a brand new PC and it would exceed most people's budgets. Or so goes the conventional 'wisdom'. Would we be willing to pay Rs 5,000 more for an operating system to power our new PC that cost us Rs 40,000 in the first place? No, we're used to getting it for 'free'.

This habit of getting and using 'free' software has made us turn a blind eye towards the legal and ethical issues involved with using pirated software. We've tasted blood. There is no way that we would now be willing to pay for software—it's just something we take for granted.

Think about the Internet boom and bust for a moment. Dotcoms tried to reinvent the wheel by offering their products and services for free. That was their biggest mistake. Would users pay for these same services after they were used to getting them for free? A majority of Hotmail.com's subscribers would look for other (read free) alternatives if Microsoft decided to charge a nominal amount for e-mail access.

But software companies have been attaching a price to their products from the very onset. It's just that we have not attached a value to them as we've never been paying up in the first place.

Reducing the cost of software is not really the answer either. How many of us have paid for that cool shareware utility we can't do without? If we are not ready to pay a couple of hundred rupees to register shareware software we use everyday, would lowering the prices of commercial software to any level help?

The burning issue is that we have a choice, the choice of using 'really free' software. But are we even willing to consider it?

Or do we wait till anti-piracy laws become so stringent that getting hold of a copy of the latest Microsoft Operating System will become next to impossible.



Vinit Aggarwal
Assistant Editor

“We’ve tasted blood. There is no way that we would now be willing to pay for software—it’s just something we take for granted”

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Vinit Aggarwal'.

vinit_aggarwal@jasubhai.com